

Far from perfect: World champion D. Gukesh (right) stumbled from one loss to another in the tournament, with critics sharpening their knives over his dip in form. MICHAL WALUSZA/FIDE

mother during the tournament, when she told him, 'It is a new month, you will play well,' helped as he turned the tables on the rest of the field.

While Praggnanandhaa showed why he is rated so highly, compatriot and World champion D. Gukesh stumbled from one loss to another in the tournament, with critics sharpening their knives over his dip in form. Strangely, he could not raise his level of play and went down in each of his last three classical matches to finish last in a high-quality field.

With the World Championship match scheduled later this year against Uzbekistan's Javokhir Sindarov, the difficulties continued to mount for Gukesh. It was another disappointing performance for the Indian, who turned 20 during the tournament. Things should ideally get better from here for the champion, who will aim to defend his title successfully.

In the women's event, which offered equal prize money, the Indians — Divya Deshmukh and Koneru Humpy (**right and below**) — brought up the rear, finishing fifth and sixth respectively.

While Divya began brightly before losing steam, Humpy's campaign never really took off as she failed to convert promising positions even when she had the upper hand.

Divya, playing in Norway Chess for the first time, exhibited flair and was the one to beat in the first half before her campaign ran into rough weather.

The Women's World Cup winner showcased the talent that made chess aficionados sit up and take notice, but it wasn't enough in a quality line-up that saw Kazakhstan's Bibisara Assaubayeva romp to victory with a round to spare.

That said, Norway Chess 2026 proved to be India's moment in the sun, with Praggnanandhaa reaffirming why the nation's players are among the most admired and feared competitors in the game.



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